

Weapons That Were Never Found

Lesson 35 — The 2003 Iraq War and its aftermath

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain the stated justifications for invasion, and why they later collapsed under scrutiny

2

Trace the war's swift military phase and the very different occupation that followed

3

Describe the insurgency's causes and the eventual troop surge response

4

Evaluate competing historians' explanations for why the war was actually fought

A new American doctrine, and an old target

The September 2001 attacks on the United States, though carried out by al-Qaeda rather than any state, reshaped American security policy toward the entire region — and returned Iraq specifically to the centre of American attention for the first time since the 1991 Gulf War.

Pre-emption, and an ‘axis of evil’

In a September 2001 address, President George W. Bush announced what became known as the Bush Doctrine — the principle that the United States could act pre-emptively against threats before they fully materialised. His January 2002 State of the Union speech named Iraq, alongside Iran and North Korea, as part of an “axis of evil” allegedly pursuing weapons of mass destruction.

Vice President Cheney, August 2002

“There is no doubt that Saddam Hussein now has weapons of mass destruction.”

Dick Cheney, address to the Veterans of Foreign Wars 103rd National Convention, 26 August 2002.

UN Resolution 1441, then a failed final mandate

UN Security Council Resolution 1441, passed November 2002, demanded Iraq readmit weapons inspectors and comply fully with earlier resolutions. When the US and UK subsequently failed to secure explicit UN authorisation for military action, they proceeded regardless, building a smaller coalition including Australia, Poland, and several other states.

19–20 March 2003: Operation Iraqi Freedom

Coalition forces invaded on 19–20 March 2003, encountering relatively light resistance from an Iraqi military still weakened by the 1991 Gulf War and a decade of sanctions. Baghdad fell after a six-day battle on 9 April, with Tikrit, Saddam's hometown, captured shortly after on 15 April — a swift, decisive military campaign lasting barely a month.

A rapid, lopsided military victory

~9,200

Iraqi combatants killed during the invasion phase

172

Coalition military deaths (139 US, 33 UK) during the same period

26 days

Duration of major combat operations

An estimated 3,750 Iraqi civilians were also killed during this initial invasion phase alone.

‘Mission Accomplished’, 1 May 2003

Speaking aboard the USS Abraham Lincoln beneath a banner reading “Mission Accomplished”, Bush declared major combat operations over. The much longer, far bloodier occupation and insurgency that actually defined the war for the next eight years had barely begun.

No weapons, ever found

A 1,400-member international Iraq Survey Group searched extensively for the weapons of mass destruction cited as the war's central justification. Its 2004 Duelfer Report concluded plainly that Iraq had no viable active WMD programme — a later US presidential commission found the administration's prewar judgements “dead wrong” in nearly every respect.

Newspaper headlines, built on unreliable sources

Between 1998 and 2003, several major American newspapers ran alarming headlines about suspected Iraqi rearmament, later shown to rely heavily on unreliable sources, including exiled Iraqi politician Ahmed Chalabi, who had his own strong interest in encouraging American intervention — a reminder that even respected media can amplify a government's case without adequately verifying it.

Bush's own later defence

Even after the WMD claims collapsed, Bush maintained in August 2004 that he would still have ordered the invasion “knowing what I know today”, arguing the world was simply “better off without Saddam Hussein in power” — shifting the war's justification, after the fact, from a specific security threat to a broader claim about removing a dictator.

So why was the war actually fought?

Historians remain divided: some argue the administration sincerely, if mistakenly, believed the WMD threat was real; others argue post-9/11 America wanted to demonstrate overwhelming resolve to any future challenger; still others point to unfinished business from the 1991 Gulf War, or a genuinely naive belief that American power could remake the region's politics for the better. No single explanation commands full consensus.

A power vacuum, and a rising insurgency

Saddam's regime collapsed, but the occupying coalition struggled to fill the resulting vacuum; widespread looting went largely unchecked, and roughly 250,000 tons of unsecured military ordnance became a significant future source of insurgent weaponry. Sunni nationalists, Ba'athist loyalists, Shia militias, and foreign jihadist fighters each launched their own campaigns of violence, often against each other as much as against coalition forces.

Fallujah, sectarian war, and the 2007 surge

Sunni insurgents and coalition forces fought two major battles for Fallujah in 2004; sectarian violence between Iraq's Shia majority and Sunni minority escalated into what amounted to civil war. In 2007, the United States deployed an additional 170,000 troops in a targeted “surge” that succeeded in stabilising significant parts of the country, if only temporarily.

Eight years, and far beyond the invasion alone

4,400+

Total US military deaths across the full war,
2003–2011

**100,000–
300,000**

Estimated Iraqi civilian deaths across the
entire conflict

2011

Year US combat troops formally withdrew

The war's instability directly contributed to the later rise of ISIS — covered in full in our next lesson.

A full essay attempt

'The 2003 Iraq War should be understood primarily as a response to genuine, if mistaken, security fears rather than a deliberate demonstration of American power.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence: the WMD claims, the Duelfer Report, and Bush's later justification
- Address at least one alternative historiographical explanation before concluding

Key terms from today

Bush Doctrine

The principle of pre-emptive military action against perceived future threats.

Sectarian insurgency

Violence dividing Iraq's Shia majority and Sunni minority after 2003.

Duelfer Report

The 2004 Iraq Survey Group finding of no viable Iraqi WMD programme.

2007 troop surge

The additional 170,000 US troops deployed to stabilise the country.

What to remember

The 2003 invasion's central justification — weapons of mass destruction — collapsed entirely under later scrutiny, while historians continue to debate the war's real underlying motive. A swift military victory gave way to a far longer, bloodier insurgency and sectarian conflict that cost hundreds of thousands of lives and helped create the conditions for ISIS's later rise.

Lesson 36 — Al-Qaeda, 9/11, and their regional impact

Next lesson steps back to examine the movement whose attacks reshaped American policy in the first place — and how the 2003 war's chaos helped its successors take root.